CHAPTER 1

THE NEW BRAND REALITY

> Authenticity is the benchmark against which all brands are now judged.
>
> John Grant, *The New Marketing Manifesto*

INTRODUCTION

Would anyone care if your brand disappeared? As I write this, the *Morgan Motor Company* (a small UK-based car manufacturer) is about to celebrate its centenary. Morganeers around the world (from as far away as New Zealand) are shipping their 'Mogs' to the village of Malvern Link to take part in this once in a lifetime celebration of a brand many business consultants predicted wouldn't see out the end of the twentieth century. At the same time, the 'Big Three' (*Chrysler*, *Ford*, and *General Motors*) are receiving financial aid (much to the consternation of the American taxpayer) from the US government. *Chrysler* has filed for bankruptcy protection (with *General Motors* likely to follow) as part of a merger deal with *Fiat*. The contrast in fortunes between the two sets of companies is as obvious as the contrast between their respective resource bases, including budgets for marketing and research and development.

In its 100-year history, *Morgan* has released seven different models of car (and you can still buy cars that were effectively designed in the 1950s), whereas barely a year goes by without a new model from the US automakers. Over the last 100 years *Morgan* has done little in the way of marketing and only recently (2005–6) started formalizing their brand position with the strap line 'Driven at Heart'. In contrast, the US automakers have invested enormous sums into marketing

M. Beverland, *Building Brand Authenticity*
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and design. While *Ford*, *Chrysler*, and *General Motors* were regularly exemplified in MBA classes, business books, and the *Harvard Business Review*, *Morgan* gained little attention from those seeking to identify best practice. In fact, at one time *Morgan* was pilloried as an example of 'all that is wrong with British industry' (Laban 2000). What is going on here?

Not everyone was oblivious to the enduring nature of the *Morgan* brand. Prior to his death Soichiro Honda predicted the car industry would eventually consist of just six manufacturers. He then paused and said 'oh, and Morgan' (Laban 2000, p. 59). Similar examples abound across the globe – remember Michael Dell's comment about closing *Apple* and returning the money to long aggrieved stockholders? Which stock would you rather own now? Why do consumers pay exorbitant sums for collectable *Altoids* tins, proudly display their *Dyson* vacuum cleaners as taste markers, get tattooed with *Apple* or *Harley Davidson* logos, trek to the ends of the earth to pay homage to their favourite brands of beer, whisky, and/or wine, and so on? What is it about these brands that make them so attractive to large numbers of consumers while more conspicuous brands (such as *Microsoft*, *Ford*, and *Pepsi*) struggle? How is it that brands which profess to 'hate marketing', 'do no market research', or 'make nothing for the customer' endure, while those that prostrate themselves before customers struggle (or are at best regarded as functional necessities)? This book proposes consumers love these brands because they are authentic.

Wait a minute. Isn't the notion of 'authentic brands' contradictory? Doesn't the very act of branding render a person or object inauthentic? How can one have authenticity when one is tainted by crass commercial motives? This book identifies how a large number of brands manage to simultaneously achieve market success while denying any interest in marketing, branding, or commercial motivations. The people running these brands paint themselves as perpetual underdogs, fighting against the blandness produced by modern marketers and the standardization of modern life. Rather than investing heavily in marketing, these brands focus on getting on with the job of making great products, seeking perfection, solving difficult problems, or offering great service. In doing so, this book offers an alternative to standard branding advice. I urge marketers to stop revelling in their expertise, stop playing safe, and reject consistency of message. Instead, marketers need to imbue their brands with a warts and all humanity and use the tools at their disposal to tell, and